

easily between the faiths is not unusual. "I wear a *taveez* during shooting and go to the Siddhi Vinayak temple a day before my movies are due for release. Islam was as much a part of my upbringing as it is of India," says the 26-year-old director.

But it's not just the new order that is reviving the Muslim social—or at least contemporary Muslim characters. Sudhir Mishra's *Khoya Khoya Chand* deals with the film era of the 1950s and the love affair between a writer-director Zaffar and an actor Nikhat. The plot came quite easily to the Lucknow-bred Mishra who is steeped in the syncretic culture of his city. In *Dhokha*, Pooja Bhatt's torn-from-daily-headlines movie, Muzamil Ibrahim plays a Muslim police officer whose educated young wife becomes a suicide bomber and whose own faith, firmly rooted in the secular

and his counterpart, the secular Muslim who vanquishes him, while the rest of the world is busy demonising Islam. It is now boldly accepting that there is a moderate Muslim as well, the ordinary citizen, faced with everyday moral choices, who has to often confront state terrorism as well as extremists from his own faith. Their choices can often be wrong (as in the case of Rehaan of *Fanaa*, who dies an unrepentant terrorist at his lover's hand), but there is a reason to why he becomes a monster.

As Mishra points out, "popular culture doesn't know the Muslim and one of the prime reasons is Bollywood's pandering to clichés. It's only now that Hindi movies are portraying aspirational Muslim characters". It could be the talented village cricketer in *Iqbal* or the feisty Gul Iqbal, the granddaughter of a fictional hockey

Altaaf in *Mission Kashmir*, there is a Sufiya Parvez who saves him. And for every Rehaan, there is a Zooni who shoots him down. When Muslim women are not showing their men the errors of their ways in questioning the state and its intentions towards the community, they are acting as emblems of sub-continental unity, a grand diasporic whole. This is light years away from the union of Waheeda Rehman's Muslim prostitute Chamilajaan with Sunil Dutt's Hindu dacoit, Thakur Jamila Singh, in *Mujhe Jeene Do*, possible partly because both were social outcasts. So Zaara Hayat Khan falls in love with Veer Pratap Singh in *Veer-Zaara*, while Alvira Khan from Lahore and Rikki Thukral of Ludhiana swear undying love in *Jhoom Barabar Jhoom* (if he has his *kada prasad*, she has the *tabarruk*).

Theirs is a determined new history which has no memories of 1947, 1965 and, even of 1999. It's a union of Indian films and Pakistani music, best reflected in the extended Hindu-Muslim *parivar* of the Bhatt (whose chief mentor Mahesh Bhatt explored the uncomfortable truth of his own divided religious identity in *Zakhm*).

So is it a return to the super Muslim of the *zarra nawazi* socials made after the success of *Chaudhvin Ka Chand* in 1959? The kind who, says Javed Akhtar, was a poet or a nawab, who lived in a haveli with chandeliers and *chilmans*? Or the street Muslim of Amitabh Bachchan's orphan in *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar* or the rebellious Iqbal

A. Khan in *Coolie*, which was for the first time transformed into the Muslim villain, the urban slumlord Lotiya Khan, of *Tezaab*? No, this is real. A modern, sometimes accomplished, yet a mostly ordinary person. ■



state, is questioned. As the writer of the film, Mahesh Bhatt, who last explored the dilemma of being a Muslim in *Zakhm* in 1998, puts it, "the inner confusion of Muslims is reflected in *Dhokha* in a six-minute sequence where the moderate is pitted against the fundamentalist. If we can depict sexual permissiveness, why not the political quandaries of our time?" In the time of Dr Mohamed Haneef, nothing could be more current.

Ironically, Bollywood seems to have woken up from the unquestioning acceptance of Muslim-equals-terrorist,

MORAL CHOICE: Devgan in *Halla Bol*; Hashmi in *Awarapan* (right)

legend, Mohammad Iqbal, in *Chak De India*'s rainbow coalition team.

In this increasingly up-to-the-minute representation of the Muslim, women have been the biggest beneficiaries. For every Amaan in *Fiza*, who turns into a terrorist, there is a Fiza who kills him. For every